01

PRATĪTYASAMUTPĀDA (Pratityasamutpada) — DEPENDENT ORIGINATION

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: Recommended opening definition: pratītyasamutpāda (dependent origination) is the principle that phenomena arise and cease in dependence on conditions, rejecting both eternalism and causeless annihilationism.

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: Recommended opening definition: pratītyasamutpāda (dependent origination) is the principle that phenomena arise and cease in dependence on conditions, rejecting both eternalism and causeless annihilationism.

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: Recommended opening definition: pratītyasamutpāda (dependent origination) is the principle that phenomena arise and cease in dependence on conditions, rejecting both eternalism and causeless annihilationism.

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

Answer-use: Recommended opening definition: pratītyasamutpāda (dependent origination) is the principle that phenomena arise and cease in dependence on conditions, rejecting both eternalism and causeless annihilationism.

ANSWER LINE: **Recommended opening definition: pratītyasamutpāda (dependent origination) is the principle that phenomena arise and cease in dependence on conditions, rejecting both eternalism and causeless annihilationism.**

02

1 Statement

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

▯ Pratītyasamutpāda means dependent origination: whatever arises, arises depending on causes and conditions; whatever ceases, ceases when those conditions cease.

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

It is the key to the arising of duḥkha and therefore the key to its cessation.

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

It is the key to the arising of duḥkha and therefore the key to its cessation.

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

▯ The standard formula, in substance, is: "imasmiṃ sati idaṃ hoti; imass' uppādā idaṃ uppajjati; imasmiṃ asati idaṃ na hoti; imassa nirodhā idaṃ nirujjhati" — this being, that becomes; from the arising of this, that arises; this not being, that is not; from the cessation of this, that ceases.

ANSWER LINE: **▯ Pratītyasamutpāda means dependent origination: whatever arises, arises depending on causes and conditions; whatever ceases, ceases when those conditions cease.**

03

2 The Four Noble Truths as the frame

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

▯ Because the origin is conditioned, it can cease.

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

▯ Because the origin is conditioned, it can cease.

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

▯ Because the origin is conditioned, it can cease.

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

Answer-use: ▯ Buddhism states the problem first: duḥkha.

ANSWER LINE: **▯ Buddhism states the problem first: duḥkha.**

04

3 The twelve nidānas in order

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

▯ The classical chain of dependent origination is expressed through the dvādaśa-nidāna sequence:

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

▯ The classical chain of dependent origination is expressed through the dvādaśa-nidāna sequence:

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

12. jarā-maraṇa — old age and death

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

Answer-use: ▯ The classical chain of dependent origination is expressed through the dvādaśa-nidāna sequence:

ANSWER LINE: **▯ The classical chain of dependent origination is expressed through the dvādaśa-nidāna sequence:**

05

4 Argument structure

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

1. ▯ What is experienced is not self-grounding; it occurs only in dependence.

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

2. ▯ If a thing were self-existent by its own nature, it would not depend on conditions.

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

4. ▯ Therefore conditioned phenomena are neither eternal substances nor sheer nothingness; they are dependent processes.

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

1. ▯ What is experienced is not self-grounding; it occurs only in dependence.

ANSWER LINE: **1. ▯ What is experienced is not self-grounding; it occurs only in dependence.**

06

5 Presupposition

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

▯▯ The doctrine presupposes that explanation should be sought through conditional relations, not through a static substratum like ātman or Brahman and not through a creator-God standing outside the chain.

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

▯▯ The doctrine presupposes that explanation should be sought through conditional relations, not through a static substratum like ātman or Brahman and not through a creator-God standing outside the chain.

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

▯▯ It also presupposes that what matters philosophically is not an absolutely first beginning but the structure by which bondage is maintained here and now.

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

▯▯ The doctrine presupposes that explanation should be sought through conditional relations, not through a static substratum like ātman or Brahman and not through a creator-God standing outside the chain.

ANSWER LINE: **▯▯ The doctrine presupposes that explanation should be sought through conditional relations, not through a static substratum like ātman or Brahman and not through a creator-God standing outside the chain.**

07

6 Distinction: middle way between extremes

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

▯ Buddhism presents dependent origination as the middle way between:

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

Because Buddhism denies permanent substance, yet it also denies that phenomena are sheer nothing.

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

ucchedavāda — annihilationism: things are sheer nullities or persons are simply obliterated without causal continuity.

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

Answer-use: ▯ Buddhism presents dependent origination as the middle way between:

ANSWER LINE: **▯ Buddhism presents dependent origination as the middle way between:**

08

7 Example

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

Yet the flame is not absolutely unreal while it burns.

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

▯▯ A flame persists only because wick, oil, oxygen and ignition remain coordinated.

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

Yet the flame is not absolutely unreal while it burns.

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

Yet the flame is not absolutely unreal while it burns.

ANSWER LINE: **▯▯ A flame persists only because wick, oil, oxygen and ignition remain coordinated.**

09

8 Objection

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

▯ If everything depends on something else, does Buddhism explain nothing ultimately?

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

Does it create an infinite regress of conditions?

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

Does it create an infinite regress of conditions?

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

Answer-use: ▯ If everything depends on something else, does Buddhism explain nothing ultimately?

ANSWER LINE: **▯ If everything depends on something else, does Buddhism explain nothing ultimately?**

10

9 Reply

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

Its primary concern is soteriological: to show that suffering is conditioned and therefore stoppable.

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

Its primary concern is soteriological: to show that suffering is conditioned and therefore stoppable.

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

Its primary concern is soteriological: to show that suffering is conditioned and therefore stoppable.

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

▯ Buddhism need not posit an unconditioned substance to make conditioning intelligible.

ANSWER LINE: **▯ Buddhism need not posit an unconditioned substance to make conditioning intelligible.**

11

10 How momentariness follows from dependent origination

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

□ Therefore what is conditioned is anitya (impermanent); Buddhist logicians radicalize this into kṣaṇikavāda, according to which what is real is momentary.

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

□ What depends on conditions cannot remain numerically identical through all times, because it changes with the rise and fall of those conditions.

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

□ Therefore what is conditioned is anitya (impermanent); Buddhist logicians radicalize this into kṣaṇikavāda, according to which what is real is momentary.

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

□ What depends on conditions cannot remain numerically identical through all times, because it changes with the rise and fall of those conditions.

ANSWER LINE: **□ What depends on conditions cannot remain numerically identical through all times, because it changes with the rise and fall of those conditions.**

12

(a) Mādhyamika: dependent origination implies emptiness

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

□ Nāgārjuna's central move is that what arises dependently cannot possess svabhāva (self-being/own-nature).

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

□ Therefore all dharmas are śūnya — empty of independent essence.

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

□ Therefore all dharmas are śūnya — empty of independent essence.

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

□ Nāgārjuna's central move is that what arises dependently cannot possess svabhāva (self-being/own-nature).

ANSWER LINE: **□ Nāgārjuna's central move is that what arises dependently cannot possess svabhāva (self-being/own-nature).**

13

(b) Vaibhāṣika / Sautrāntika: dependent origination implies conditioned reality

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

□ The realist Buddhist schools agree that things arise dependently.

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

□ But instead of inferring emptiness of all dharmas in the Mādhyamika sense, they say: precisely because things arise causally, they are real as conditioned entities.

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

□□ Thus the same causal thesis can support two ontological emphases: absence of self-nature, or reality of conditioned events.

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

□ Vaibhāṣika treats dharmas as real and directly knowable; Sautrāntika treats them as real though not directly perceived externally.

ANSWER LINE: **□ The realist Buddhist schools agree that things arise dependently.**

14

12 Cessation and knowledge

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

□ Ignorance of dependent origination is bondage; insight into it is release.

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

□□ Therefore the 2023 question — ignorance of dependent origination is suffering while its knowledge is cessation — should be answered not as a mere epistemic slogan, but as a claim that wrong metaphysical grasping fuels craving and hence suffering.

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

□□ Therefore the 2023 question — ignorance of dependent origination is suffering while its knowledge is cessation — should be answered not as a mere epistemic slogan, but as a claim that wrong metaphysical grasping fuels craving and hence suffering.

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

□□ Therefore the 2023 question — ignorance of dependent origination is suffering while its knowledge is cessation — should be answered not as a mere epistemic slogan, but as a claim that wrong metaphysical grasping fuels craving and hence suffering.

ANSWER LINE: **□ Ignorance of dependent origination is bondage; insight into it is release.**

15

KṢAṆIKAVĀDA (Ksanikavada) — DOCTRINE OF MOMENTARINESS

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: Kṣaṇikavāda (doctrine of momentariness) holds that whatever is causally efficient exists only momentarily, because a permanent entity could neither change its causal power nor produce genuinely successive effects.

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: Kṣaṇikavāda (doctrine of momentariness) holds that whatever is causally efficient exists only momentarily, because a permanent entity could neither change its causal power nor produce genuinely successive effects.

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: Kṣaṇikavāda (doctrine of momentariness) holds that whatever is causally efficient exists only momentarily, because a permanent entity could neither change its causal power nor produce genuinely successive effects.

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

Answer-use: Kṣaṇikavāda (doctrine of momentariness) holds that whatever is causally efficient exists only momentarily, because a permanent entity could neither change its causal power nor produce genuinely successive effects.

ANSWER LINE: **Kṣaṇikavāda (doctrine of momentariness) holds that whatever is causally efficient exists only momentarily, because a permanent entity could neither change its causal power nor produce genuinely successive effects.**

16

1 Statement

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

□ Kṣaṇikavāda holds that whatever is real is momentary.

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

□ A standard scholastic formulation runs in substance as: whatever is truly real is momentary (sattve satyeva kṣaṇikatvam).

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

□□ The doctrine is not that nothing exists; it is that reality is evental rather than substantial.

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

□□ The doctrine is not that nothing exists; it is that reality is evental rather than substantial.

ANSWER LINE: **□ Kṣaṇikavāda holds that whatever is real is momentary.**

17

Statement

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

□ Arthakriyākāritva (causal efficacy / capacity to perform a function) is the Buddhist pramāṇa-school criterion of the real: sat = arthakriyā-samartha — the real is what is capable of producing an effect.

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

□ Kṣaṇikavāda follows because whatever is causally effective must be moment-specific; a wholly permanent entity cannot explain why an effect appears now rather than always.

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

□ Arthakriyākāritva (causal efficacy / capacity to perform a function) is the Buddhist pramāṇa-school criterion of the real: sat = arthakriyā-samartha — the real is what is capable of producing an effect.

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

□ Kṣaṇikavāda follows because whatever is causally effective must be moment-specific; a wholly permanent entity cannot explain why an effect appears now rather than always.

ANSWER LINE: **□ Arthakriyākāritva (causal efficacy / capacity to perform a function) is the Buddhist pramāṇa-school criterion of the real: sat = arthakriyā-samartha — the real is what is capable of producing an effect.**

18

Argument

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

1. □ To be real is to be causally efficacious; an entity that makes no difference is indistinguishable from a non-entity for Buddhist analysis.

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

6. □ Therefore a permanent entity cannot coherently be causally efficient.

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

3. □ If a permanent entity produces its effect all at once, nothing remains for later production; this is the yaugapadya (simultaneity) horn.

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

4. □ If it produces effects successively, then it functions differently at different moments; what functions differently is not wholly permanent.

ANSWER LINE: **1. □ To be real is to be causally efficacious; an entity that makes no difference is indistinguishable from a non-entity for Buddhist analysis.**

19

Presupposition

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

□□ The argument presupposes a pragmatic-realist criterion: reality is not inert self-identity but effect-producing capacity.

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

□□ It also presupposes that a single unchanged entity cannot have genuinely different causal profiles at different times without ceasing to be unchanged.

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

□□ The argument presupposes a pragmatic-realist criterion: reality is not inert self-identity but effect-producing capacity.

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

□□ The argument presupposes a pragmatic-realist criterion: reality is not inert self-identity but effect-producing capacity.

ANSWER LINE: **□□ The argument presupposes a pragmatic-realist criterion: reality is not inert self-identity but effect-producing capacity.**

20

Example

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

□□ A seed is real because it can issue in a sprout.

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

□□ A seed is real because it can issue in a sprout.

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

But the seed that has exercised that precise sprout-producing capacity is no longer the same causal phase; the series has advanced.

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

Answer-use: □□ A seed is real because it can issue in a sprout.

ANSWER LINE: **□□ A seed is real because it can issue in a sprout.**

21

Objection — Nyāya (Vātsyāyana / Uddyotakara / Udayana line)

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

▯ Nyāya asks: why can a permanent substance not act at one time because relevant auxiliary conditions are then present?

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

▯ Nyāya asks: why can a permanent substance not act at one time because relevant auxiliary conditions are then present?

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

▯ Nyāya also uses pratyabhijñā (recognition — “this is that same jar”), memory and moral desert to argue that enduring substances and selves are required.

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

▯ Nyāya asks: why can a permanent substance not act at one time because relevant auxiliary conditions are then present?

ANSWER LINE: **▯ Nyāya asks: why can a permanent substance not act at one time because relevant auxiliary conditions are then present?**

22

Reply — Buddhist logicians

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

▯ The Buddhist reply is that if the permanent thing remains wholly unchanged, then the decisive factor lies elsewhere; its own efficacy is redundant.

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

▯ Recognition is explained through sādṛśya (similarity) within a causal stream, not strict numerical identity.

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

▯ Memory and desert are explained through santāna / santati (causal continuum), with ālaya-vijñāna and bīja (seeds) supplying the Yogācāra version of the continuity device.

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

▯ Recognition is explained through sādṛśya (similarity) within a causal stream, not strict numerical identity.

ANSWER LINE: **▯ The Buddhist reply is that if the permanent thing remains wholly unchanged, then the decisive factor lies elsewhere; its own efficacy is redundant.**

23

3 Argument from destruction (vināśitvānumāna / kṣaṇabhaṅga line)

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

▯ The very nature of the conditioned is to perish; arising already contains ceasing.

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

▯ The very nature of the conditioned is to perish; arising already contains ceasing.

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

▯▯ Hence things are not first fully stable entities and later destroyed; their transience belongs to what they are.

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

▯ Another line of reasoning holds that destruction does not require a second, separate destroyer added from outside.

ANSWER LINE: **▯ Another line of reasoning holds that destruction does not require a second, separate destroyer added from outside.**

24

4 Apparent continuity: santāna

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

▯ If everything is momentary, why does the world look continuous?

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

▯ Buddhism answers through santāna — a causal series or stream.

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

▯ Each moment gives rise to the next sufficiently similar moment, producing the appearance of persistence.

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

Answer-use: ▯ If everything is momentary, why does the world look continuous?

ANSWER LINE: **▯ If everything is momentary, why does the world look continuous?**

25

Objection — Nyāya (Vātsyāyana / Uddyotakara / Udayana line)

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

▯ If the rememberer is numerically different from the experiencer, how can there be personal identity or moral responsibility?

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

▯ If the rememberer is numerically different from the experiencer, how can there be personal identity or moral responsibility?

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

▯ If the rememberer is numerically different from the experiencer, how can there be personal identity or moral responsibility?

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

Answer-use: ▯ If every mental state perishes instantly, then who remembers a past event?

ANSWER LINE: **▯ If every mental state perishes instantly, then who remembers a past event?**

26

Buddhist replies

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

1. ▯ Santāna: memory belongs to the same causal stream, not to a permanent self.

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

2. ▯ Pratisandhāna: reconnection/relinking explains continuity across moments and lives.

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

3. ▯ Ālaya-vijñāna in Yogācāra: a store-consciousness carries latent impressions (bīja, seeds), explaining the preservation of karmic and mnemonic potential.

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

1. ▯ Santāna: memory belongs to the same causal stream, not to a permanent self.

ANSWER LINE: **1. ▯ Santāna: memory belongs to the same causal stream, not to a permanent self.**

27

Philosophical point

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

▯▯ The Buddhist answer is deliberately middle-path: the later subject is neither strictly the same nor wholly other than the earlier one.

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

▯▯ The Buddhist answer is deliberately middle-path: the later subject is neither strictly the same nor wholly other than the earlier one.

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

▯▯ The Buddhist answer is deliberately middle-path: the later subject is neither strictly the same nor wholly other than the earlier one.

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

Answer-use: ▯▯ The Buddhist answer is deliberately middle-path: the later subject is neither strictly the same nor wholly other than the earlier one.

ANSWER LINE: **▯▯ The Buddhist answer is deliberately middle-path: the later subject is neither strictly the same nor wholly other than the earlier one.**

28

Problem

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

▯ Karma seems to require a persisting moral subject: the doer should receive the fruit.

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

▯ Karma seems to require a persisting moral subject: the doer should receive the fruit.

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

▯ Karma seems to require a persisting moral subject: the doer should receive the fruit.

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

Answer-use: ▯ Karma seems to require a persisting moral subject: the doer should receive the fruit.

ANSWER LINE: **▯ Karma seems to require a persisting moral subject: the doer should receive the fruit.**

29

Buddhist answer

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

▯ The relation is neither identity nor utter difference.

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

▯ The relation is neither identity nor utter difference.

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

▯▯ If it were strict identity, Buddhism would collapse into eternalism; if it were total difference, responsibility would collapse.

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

Answer-use: ▯ The stream receives the fruit of what the earlier stream-stage performed.

ANSWER LINE: **▯ The stream receives the fruit of what the earlier stream-stage performed.**

30

7 Example

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

The second flame is not numerically the first, yet it is causally connected to it.

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

Rebirth and karmic fruition are often explained analogically in this way.

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

Rebirth and karmic fruition are often explained analogically in this way.

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

The second flame is not numerically the first, yet it is causally connected to it.

ANSWER LINE: **The second flame is not numerically the first, yet it is causally connected to it.**

31

8 Objection — Nyāya pratyabhijñā argument

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

□ Recognition such as "this is the same person I met before" appears to require enduring identity, not merely stream-likeness.

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

□ Recognition such as "this is the same person I met before" appears to require enduring identity, not merely stream-likeness.

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

□ Recognition such as "this is the same person I met before" appears to require enduring identity, not merely stream-likeness.

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

□ Recognition such as "this is the same person I met before" appears to require enduring identity, not merely stream-likeness.

ANSWER LINE: **□ Recognition such as "this is the same person I met before" appears to require enduring identity, not merely stream-likeness.**

32

9 Reply

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

□ Buddhism can say recognition tracks practical continuity and similarity within a series, not metaphysical identity of a substance.

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

□□ The language of sameness belongs to conventional truth; ultimate analysis reveals only a flow of conditioned moments.

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

□□ The language of sameness belongs to conventional truth; ultimate analysis reveals only a flow of conditioned moments.

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

□ Buddhism can say recognition tracks practical continuity and similarity within a series, not metaphysical identity of a substance.

ANSWER LINE: **□ Buddhism can say recognition tracks practical continuity and similarity within a series, not metaphysical identity of a substance.**

33

NAIRĀTMYAVĀDA (Nairatmyavada) — NO-SELF DOCTRINE

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: Nairātmyavāda (no-self doctrine) denies an eternal ātman (self) and explains the person as a dependently ordered continuum of five skandhas (aggregates), preserving conventional identity without a permanent substance.

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: Nairātmyavāda (no-self doctrine) denies an eternal ātman (self) and explains the person as a dependently ordered continuum of five skandhas (aggregates), preserving conventional identity without a permanent substance.

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: Nairātmyavāda (no-self doctrine) denies an eternal ātman (self) and explains the person as a dependently ordered continuum of five skandhas (aggregates), preserving conventional identity without a permanent substance.

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

Answer-use: Nairātmyavāda (no-self doctrine) denies an eternal ātman (self) and explains the person as a dependently ordered continuum of five skandhas (aggregates), preserving conventional identity without a permanent substance.

ANSWER LINE: **Nairātmyavāda (no-self doctrine) denies an eternal ātman (self) and explains the person as a dependently ordered continuum of five skandhas (aggregates), preserving conventional identity without a permanent substance.**

34

1 Statement

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

□ What is conventionally called a person is only an aggregate of changing factors.

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

□ What is conventionally called a person is only an aggregate of changing factors.

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

□ What is conventionally called a person is only an aggregate of changing factors.

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

Answer-use: □ Nairātmyavāda or anātmavāda denies a permanent, unchanging ātman behind experience.

ANSWER LINE: **□ Nairātmyavāda or anātmavāda denies a permanent, unchanging ātman behind experience.**

35

2 The five skandhas

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

□ The person is analysed into five skandhas:

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

4. saṃskāra — dispositions/formations

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

□□ The philosophical force of the doctrine lies in exhaustive analysis: if what we call self reduces to these aggregates and no extra owner is found, the self is a conceptual imputation, not an independently real substance.

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

□□ The philosophical force of the doctrine lies in exhaustive analysis: if what we call self reduces to these aggregates and no extra owner is found, the self is a conceptual imputation, not an independently real substance.

ANSWER LINE: **□ The person is analysed into five skandhas:**

36

3 Chariot analogy (Milinda-pañha)

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

▯ The classic chariot analogy argues that "chariot" is merely a name for the arrangement of axle, wheels, yoke and other parts.

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

▯ Likewise, "person" is a conventional designation for the aggregate of skandhas.

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

▯▯ The point is not that the person is uselessly unreal.

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

▯▯ The point is not that the person is uselessly unreal.

ANSWER LINE: **▯ The classic chariot analogy argues that "chariot" is merely a name for the arrangement of axle, wheels, yoke and other parts.**

37

Pudgala-nairātmya

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

▯ This is the minimum no-self thesis common to Buddhism.

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

▯ This is the minimum no-self thesis common to Buddhism.

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

▯ This is the minimum no-self thesis common to Buddhism.

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

Answer-use: ▯ Denial of a permanent personal self (pudgala, person).

ANSWER LINE: **▯ Denial of a permanent personal self (pudgala, person).**

38

Dharma-nairātmya

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

▯ This is developed most strongly in Mahāyāna, especially Mādhyamika.

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

▯ This is developed most strongly in Mahāyāna, especially Mādhyamika.

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

▯ This is developed most strongly in Mahāyāna, especially Mādhyamika.

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

Answer-use: ▯ Denial that even dharmas possess intrinsic self-nature.

ANSWER LINE: **▯ Denial that even dharmas possess intrinsic self-nature.**

39

School difference

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

▯ Hīnayāna / early realist schools: primarily affirm pudgala-nairātmya; dharmas are treated as real.

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

▯ Mahāyāna: affirms both pudgala-nairātmya and dharma-nairātmya; neither person nor dharma has svabhāva.

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

▯ Mahāyāna: affirms both pudgala-nairātmya and dharma-nairātmya; neither person nor dharma has svabhāva.

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

Answer-use: ▯ Hīnayāna / early realist schools: primarily affirm pudgala-nairātmya; dharmas are treated as real.

ANSWER LINE: **▯ Hīnayāna / early realist schools: primarily affirm pudgala-nairātmya; dharmas are treated as real.**

40

5 The Puggalavāda foil

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

▯ Some Buddhist groups, often associated with the Vātsīputrīyas, proposed a pudgala that is neither the same as nor different from the skandhas.

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

▯▯ In answers, use Puggalavāda as a foil: it shows that the pressure to preserve moral continuity was real, but orthodox Buddhist thought refused to answer it by reintroducing a substantial person.

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

▯▯ In answers, use Puggalavāda as a foil: it shows that the pressure to preserve moral continuity was real, but orthodox Buddhist thought refused to answer it by reintroducing a substantial person.

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

Answer-use: ▯ Some Buddhist groups, often associated with the Vātsīputrīyas, proposed a pudgala that is neither the same as nor different from the skandhas.

ANSWER LINE: **▯ Some Buddhist groups, often associated with the Vātsīputrīyas, proposed a pudgala that is neither the same as nor different from the skandhas.**

41

Problem

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

▯ If there is no self, who takes refuge in the Triratna — Buddha, Dharma, Saṅgha?

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

▯ If there is no self, who takes refuge in the Triratna — Buddha, Dharma, Saṅgha?

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

▯ If there is no self, who takes refuge in the Triratna — Buddha, Dharma, Saṅgha?

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

Answer-use: ▯ If there is no self, who takes refuge in the Triratna — Buddha, Dharma, Saṅgha?

ANSWER LINE: **▯ If there is no self, who takes refuge in the Triratna — Buddha, Dharma, Saṅgha?**

42

Reply

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

▯ Buddhism can answer: the refuge-taker is the conventional person, a prajñapti-puruṣa or designated person, not an ultimately real soul.

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

▯ Ethical and spiritual practice proceeds at the level of conventional truth without requiring metaphysical ātman.

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

▯▯ Thus anātman does not abolish discipline; it purifies it of ego-metaphysics.

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

▯ Buddhism can answer: the refuge-taker is the conventional person, a prajñapti-puruṣa or designated person, not an ultimately real soul.

ANSWER LINE: **▯ Buddhism can answer: the refuge-taker is the conventional person, a prajñapti-puruṣa or designated person, not an ultimately real soul.**

43

7 Nirvāṇa

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

▯ Nirvāṇa is the cessation of suffering and the extinguishing of the three fires: rāga (attachment), dveṣa (aversion), and moha (delusion).

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

▯ It is not best understood as a substantial place or eternal self-state gained by an entity.

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

▯▯ It is the cessation of the very process that produces bondage.

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

▯ It is not best understood as a substantial place or eternal self-state gained by an entity.

ANSWER LINE: **▯ Nirvāṇa is the cessation of suffering and the extinguishing of the three fires: rāga (attachment), dveṣa (aversion), and moha (delusion).**

44

Objection — Śaṃkara-type Advaita and Nyāya realist

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

▯ If there is no self, who attains nirvāṇa?

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

▯ If everything is momentary, what persists in liberation?

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

▯ If everything is momentary, what persists in liberation?

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

Answer-use: ▯ If there is no self, who attains nirvāṇa?

ANSWER LINE: **▯ If there is no self, who attains nirvāṇa?**

45

Reply

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

2. ▯ Nirvāṇa is not an entity possessed by a soul.

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

2. ▯ Nirvāṇa is not an entity possessed by a soul.

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

3. ▯ It is the cessation of craving, ignorance and the suffering-series grounded in them.

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

2. ▯ Nirvāṇa is not an entity possessed by a soul.

ANSWER LINE: **1. ▯ The question "who attains?" assumes the very self Buddhism rejects.**

46

Theravāda and Mahāyāna nuance

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

□ In Nāgārjuna's radical language, saṃsāra and nirvāṇa are not two independent realms; the difference lies in how dependent reality is grasped.

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

□ Mahāyāna: emphasizes the bodhisattva ideal and universal liberation.

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

□ In Nāgārjuna's radical language, saṃsāra and nirvāṇa are not two independent realms; the difference lies in how dependent reality is grasped.

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

□ In Nāgārjuna's radical language, saṃsāra and nirvāṇa are not two independent realms; the difference lies in how dependent reality is grasped.

ANSWER LINE: **□ Theravāda: emphasizes individual nibbāna and the arhat ideal.**

47

THE FOUR SCHOOLS OF BUDDHISM

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: The four-school debate moves from Vaibhāṣika (Abhidharma realist school) and Sautrāntika (Sūtra-based representationalist school) to Yogācāra (yoga-practice consciousness-centred school) and Mādhyamika (Middle Way emptiness school), progressively questioning what can count as ultimately real.

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: The four-school debate moves from Vaibhāṣika (Abhidharma realist school) and Sautrāntika (Sūtra-based representationalist school) to Yogācāra (yoga-practice consciousness-centred school) and Mādhyamika (Middle Way emptiness school), progressively questioning what can count as ultimately real.

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: The four-school debate moves from Vaibhāṣika (Abhidharma realist school) and Sautrāntika (Sūtra-based representationalist school) to Yogācāra (yoga-practice consciousness-centred school) and Mādhyamika (Middle Way emptiness school), progressively questioning what can count as ultimately real.

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

Answer-use: The four-school debate moves from Vaibhāṣika (Abhidharma realist school) and Sautrāntika (Sūtra-based representationalist school) to Yogācāra (yoga-practice consciousness-centred school) and Mādhyamika (Middle Way emptiness school), progressively questioning what can count as ultimately real.

ANSWER LINE: **The four-school debate moves from Vaibhāṣika (Abhidharma realist school) and Sautrāntika (Sūtra-based representationalist school) to Yogācāra (yoga-practice consciousness-centred school) and Mādhyamika (Middle Way emptiness school), progressively questioning what can count as ultimately real.**

48

1 Vaibhāṣika

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

□ Usually associated with Sarvāstivāda realism.

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

□ Holds bāhya-pratyakṣa-vāda: external objects are directly perceived.

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

□ Affirms sarvam asti in the technical sense that dharmas of past, present and future have some mode of existence.

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

Answer-use: □ Usually associated with Sarvāstivāda realism.

ANSWER LINE: **□ Usually associated with Sarvāstivāda realism.**

49

Philosophical significance

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

□□ Vaibhāṣika preserves Buddhist anti-self doctrine while still maintaining a robust realism about dharmas.

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

□□ It is therefore a useful contrast both to Yogācāra idealism and to Mādhyamika anti-essentialism.

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

□□ It is therefore a useful contrast both to Yogācāra idealism and to Mādhyamika anti-essentialism.

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

Answer-use: □□ Vaibhāṣika preserves Buddhist anti-self doctrine while still maintaining a robust realism about dharmas.

ANSWER LINE: **□□ Vaibhāṣika preserves Buddhist anti-self doctrine while still maintaining a robust realism about dharmas.**

50

2 Sautrāntika

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

□ Holds bāhyānumeya-vāda: external objects exist, but are known only inferentially through mental representations.

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

□ Holds bāhyānumeya-vāda: external objects exist, but are known only inferentially through mental representations.

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

□ Strongly privileges the present moment.

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

Answer-use: □ Holds bāhyānumeya-vāda: external objects exist, but are known only inferentially through mental representations.

ANSWER LINE: **□ Holds bāhyānumeya-vāda: external objects exist, but are known only inferentially through mental representations.**

51

Statement

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

▯ What appears as external object is inseparable from modes of consciousness.

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

▯ What appears as external object is inseparable from modes of consciousness.

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

▯ What appears as external object is inseparable from modes of consciousness.

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

Answer-use: ▯ Yogācāra advances vijñaptimātra or consciousness-only.

ANSWER LINE: **▯ Yogācāra advances vijñaptimātra or consciousness-only.**

52

Key doctrine: ālaya-vijñāna

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

▯ The ālaya-vijñāna (store-consciousness) preserves karmic seeds (bījas), explaining continuity, memory and rebirth without a permanent self.

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

▯ The ālaya-vijñāna (store-consciousness) preserves karmic seeds (bījas), explaining continuity, memory and rebirth without a permanent self.

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

▯ The ālaya-vijñāna (store-consciousness) preserves karmic seeds (bījas), explaining continuity, memory and rebirth without a permanent self.

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

Answer-use: ▯ The ālaya-vijñāna (store-consciousness) preserves karmic seeds (bījas), explaining continuity, memory and rebirth without a permanent self.

ANSWER LINE: **▯ The ālaya-vijñāna (store-consciousness) preserves karmic seeds (bījas), explaining continuity, memory and rebirth without a permanent self.**

53

Arguments against external realism

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

Hence external atomism is unstable.

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

1. ▯ Dream argument: dream-objects are vividly experienced despite lacking corresponding external objects; therefore experienced objecthood does not prove external independent matter.

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

1. ▯ Dream argument: dream-objects are vividly experienced despite lacking corresponding external objects; therefore experienced objecthood does not prove external independent matter.

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

1. ▯ Dream argument: dream-objects are vividly experienced despite lacking corresponding external objects; therefore experienced objecthood does not prove external independent matter.

ANSWER LINE: **1. ▯ Dream argument: dream-objects are vividly experienced despite lacking corresponding external objects; therefore experienced objecthood does not prove external independent matter.**

54

Tri-svabhāva (three natures)

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

▯▯ These explain how deluded objectification arises and how it is overcome.

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

▯ paratantra-svabhāva — dependent nature

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

▯ pariniṣpanna-svabhāva — perfected/consummate nature

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

Answer-use: ▯ parikalpita-svabhāva — imagined nature

ANSWER LINE: **▯ parikalpita-svabhāva — imagined nature**

55

Statement

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

▯ The central thesis is śūnyatā (emptiness): absence of svabhāva (intrinsic nature / own-being), not sheer nothingness.

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

▯ The central thesis is śūnyatā (emptiness): absence of svabhāva (intrinsic nature / own-being), not sheer nothingness.

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

▯ In substance, Nāgārjuna identifies dependent origination and emptiness: what is dependently arisen is empty of independent essence.

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

▯ The central thesis is śūnyatā (emptiness): absence of svabhāva (intrinsic nature / own-being), not sheer nothingness.

ANSWER LINE: **▯ Associated especially with Nāgārjuna.**

56

Catuṣkoṭi — the four corners

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

▯▯ Thus the early use is primarily therapeutic and soteriological; the Madhyamaka use is also logical-ontological, because it exposes the incoherence of intrinsic nature.

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

▯ Early / Nikāya use: the avyākata / avyākṛta questions are often framed through four alternatives, and all four are set aside because they do not conduce to liberation and rest on misleading presuppositions.

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

▯▯ Thus the early use is primarily therapeutic and soteriological; the Madhyamaka use is also logical-ontological, because it exposes the incoherence of intrinsic nature.

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

▯ Early / Nikāya use: the avyākata / avyākṛta questions are often framed through four alternatives, and all four are set aside because they do not conduce to liberation and rest on misleading presuppositions.

ANSWER LINE: **▯ Early / Nikāya use: the avyākata / avyākṛta questions are often framed through four alternatives, and all four are set aside because they do not conduce to liberation and rest on misleading presuppositions.**

57

Crucial logical nuance — why this is not simple contradiction

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

▯ Madhyamaka negation is best read as prasajya-pratiṣedha (non-implicative / commitment-free negation), not paryudāsa-pratiṣedha (implicative negation that asserts a positive alternative).

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

▯ The four corners are denied of things taken as having svabhāva; once svabhāva is dropped, the denial does not install a fifth positive thesis.

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

▯ Hence Nāgārjuna can claim, in the spirit of the Vigrahavyāvartanī, that he has no independent pratijñā (thesis) of his own.

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

▯ Madhyamaka negation is best read as prasajya-pratiṣedha (non-implicative / commitment-free negation), not paryudāsa-pratiṣedha (implicative negation that asserts a positive alternative).

ANSWER LINE: **▯ Madhyamaka negation is best read as prasajya-pratiṣedha (non-implicative / commitment-free negation), not paryudāsa-pratiṣedha (implicative negation that asserts a positive alternative).**

58

Two truths as the anti-nihilist frame

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

▯ Conventional truth is not mere falsehood; it is the domain within which practical life and Buddhist discipline function.

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

▯ Ultimate truth is insight into the emptiness of all reified positions.

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

▯ Nāgārjuna warns that emptiness wrongly grasped destroys the dull-witted, like a snake wrongly seized.

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

▯ Conventional truth is not mere falsehood; it is the domain within which practical life and Buddhist discipline function.

ANSWER LINE: **▯ Conventional truth is not mere falsehood; it is the domain within which practical life and Buddhist discipline function.**

59

Objection — Nyāya / Uddyotakara-type and modern irrationalism charge

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

▯ The opponent adds: the denial itself is a thesis, so the claim “I have no thesis” is self-refuting.

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

▯ The opponent adds: the denial itself is a thesis, so the claim “I have no thesis” is self-refuting.

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

▯ The opponent adds: the denial itself is a thesis, so the claim “I have no thesis” is self-refuting.

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

Answer-use: ▯ The opponent says: if all four alternatives are denied, the Mādhyamika either says nothing or contradicts himself.

ANSWER LINE: **▯ The opponent says: if all four alternatives are denied, the Mādhyamika either says nothing or contradicts himself.**

60

Reply — Nāgārjuna and later Madhyamaka

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

▯ Nāgārjuna's reply is the “my words are empty too” move: his statements do not possess svabhāva and therefore do not create a positive ontological commitment.

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

▯ Nāgārjuna's reply is the “my words are empty too” move: his statements do not possess svabhāva and therefore do not create a positive ontological commitment.

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

▯ Nāgārjuna's reply is the “my words are empty too” move: his statements do not possess svabhāva and therefore do not create a positive ontological commitment.

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

▯ Nāgārjuna's reply is the “my words are empty too” move: his statements do not possess svabhāva and therefore do not create a positive ontological commitment.

ANSWER LINE: **▯ Nāgārjuna's reply is the “my words are empty too” move: his statements do not possess svabhāva and therefore do not create a positive ontological commitment.**

61

Śūnyatā is not nihilism

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

▯ To say things are empty is to say they lack svabhāva.

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

▯ It is not to say they are absent in every sense.

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

▯ Since conventional truth remains operative, compassion, karma and the path are not denied.

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

▯ It is not to say they are absent in every sense.

ANSWER LINE: **▯ To say things are empty is to say they lack svabhāva.**

62

BUDDHIST ARGUMENTS AGAINST A CREATOR GOD

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

▯▯ This is a cross-paper theme and should be linked with Proofs for God and Religion without God.

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

▯▯ This is a cross-paper theme and should be linked with Proofs for God and Religion without God.

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: The Buddhist critique holds that a permanent and perfect creator cannot intelligibly initiate changing effects, acquire a new will, or remain morally insulated from the suffering attributed to creation.

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: The Buddhist critique holds that a permanent and perfect creator cannot intelligibly initiate changing effects, acquire a new will, or remain morally insulated from the suffering attributed to creation.

ANSWER LINE: **The Buddhist critique holds that a permanent and perfect creator cannot intelligibly initiate changing effects, acquire a new will, or remain morally insulated from the suffering attributed to creation.**

63

1 Core lines of criticism

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

▯ If God is eternal and unchanging, genuine creation becomes difficult to explain, because willing or producing seems to involve change.

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

▯ If God is eternal and unchanging, genuine creation becomes difficult to explain, because willing or producing seems to involve change.

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

▯ The presence of suffering and evil sits uneasily with an omnipotent benevolent creator.

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

Answer-use: ▯ If God is eternal and unchanging, genuine creation becomes difficult to explain, because willing or producing seems to involve change.

ANSWER LINE: **▯ If God is eternal and unchanging, genuine creation becomes difficult to explain, because willing or producing seems to involve change.**

64

2 Philosophical force

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

▯▯ Buddhist critique is not mere atheistic denial; it is a systematic refusal of explanatory surplus.

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

If conditioned arising explains the world-process, God is not needed.

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

If conditioned arising explains the world-process, God is not needed.

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

▯▯ Buddhist critique is not mere atheistic denial; it is a systematic refusal of explanatory surplus.

ANSWER LINE: **▯▯ Buddhist critique is not mere atheistic denial; it is a systematic refusal of explanatory surplus.**

65

INTER-THINKER / INTER-SCHOOL DEBATES

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

Buddhist schools share dependent origination and no-self but disagree over external objects, consciousness and ultimate truth; comparison must therefore preserve both their common therapeutic framework and their distinct ontologies.

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: Buddhist schools share dependent origination and no-self but disagree over external objects, consciousness and ultimate truth; comparison must therefore preserve both their common therapeutic framework and their distinct ontologies.

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: Buddhist schools share dependent origination and no-self but disagree over external objects, consciousness and ultimate truth; comparison must therefore preserve both their common therapeutic framework and their distinct ontologies.

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

Answer-use: Buddhist schools share dependent origination and no-self but disagree over external objects, consciousness and ultimate truth; comparison must therefore preserve both their common therapeutic framework and their distinct ontologies.

ANSWER LINE: **Buddhist schools share dependent origination and no-self but disagree over external objects, consciousness and ultimate truth; comparison must therefore preserve both their common therapeutic framework and their distinct ontologies.**

66

1 Carvāka's rejection of self vs Buddhist rejection of ātman (2024)

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

▯ Carvāka denies self beyond body and tends toward materialist reduction.

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

▯▯ Therefore both reject an eternal ātman, but for very different reasons and with very different moral-metaphysical consequences.

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

▯▯ Therefore both reject an eternal ātman, but for very different reasons and with very different moral-metaphysical consequences.

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

▯ Buddhism denies permanent self but does not reduce personhood simply to gross body; it analyses the person into skandhas and preserves karmic continuity without substance.

ANSWER LINE: **▯ Carvāka denies self beyond body and tends toward materialist reduction.**

67

2 Internal Buddhist pūrvapakṣa chain — how the four schools answer one another

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

▯▯ Exam payoff: for "Schools of Buddhism", do not list four schools mechanically.

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

Present them as an argumentative escalation: realism of dharmas → presentist representationalism → idealist consciousness-only → anti-essentialist emptiness.

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

Present them as an argumentative escalation: realism of dharmas → presentist representationalism → idealist consciousness-only → anti-essentialist emptiness.

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

▯▯ Exam payoff: for "Schools of Buddhism", do not list four schools mechanically.

ANSWER LINE: **▯▯ Exam payoff: for "Schools of Buddhism", do not list four schools mechanically.**

68

CRITICISMS AND REPLIES — NAMED PŪRVAPAKṢA

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: The central realist criticism is that momentariness and no-self cannot explain recognition, memory and moral responsibility; the Buddhist reply relocates continuity from substance to causally connected santāna (continuum).

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: The central realist criticism is that momentariness and no-self cannot explain recognition, memory and moral responsibility; the Buddhist reply relocates continuity from substance to causally connected santāna (continuum).

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: The central realist criticism is that momentariness and no-self cannot explain recognition, memory and moral responsibility; the Buddhist reply relocates continuity from substance to causally connected santāna (continuum).

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: The central realist criticism is that momentariness and no-self cannot explain recognition, memory and moral responsibility; the Buddhist reply relocates continuity from substance to causally connected santāna (continuum).

ANSWER LINE: **The central realist criticism is that momentariness and no-self cannot explain recognition, memory and moral responsibility; the Buddhist reply relocates continuity from substance to causally connected santāna (continuum).**

69

Objection — Nyāya (Vātsyāyana / Uddyotakara / Udayana line)

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

▯ Pratyabhijñā (recognition) — "this is that same jar" or "I am the same person who saw before" — appears to disclose identity through time.

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

▯ Pratyabhijñā (recognition) — "this is that same jar" or "I am the same person who saw before" — appears to disclose identity through time.

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

▯ Moral desert seems to require an enduring agent: the doer of an act must be the enjoyer or sufferer of its fruit.

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

Answer-use: ▯ Pratyabhijñā (recognition) — "this is that same jar" or "I am the same person who saw before" — appears to disclose identity through time.

ANSWER LINE: **▯ Pratyabhijñā (recognition) — "this is that same jar" or "I am the same person who saw before" — appears to disclose identity through time.**

70

Reply — Buddhist schools

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

▯ The flame and river examples show continuity without strict identity: a later flame or river-stage is neither wholly the same nor wholly other.

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

▯ Sādṛśya (similarity) explains why recognition mistakes a later similar causal phase for the numerically same object.

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

▯ The flame and river examples show continuity without strict identity: a later flame or river-stage is neither wholly the same nor wholly other.

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

Answer-use: ▯ Santāna / santati (causal series) explains continuity without an identical substance.

ANSWER LINE: **▯ Santāna / santati (causal series) explains continuity without an identical substance.**

71

Objection — Kumārila Bhaṭṭa

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

▯ Mīmāṃsā defends a persisting self as the subject of cognition, duty, memory and Vedic action.

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

▯ Kumārila also resists apoha by arguing that general words and recognition require positive universals, not merely exclusion.

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

▯ A merely negative meaning such as "not-non-cow" seems unable to explain the positive cognition "cow".

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

▯ Kumārila also resists apoha by arguing that general words and recognition require positive universals, not merely exclusion.

ANSWER LINE: **▯ Mīmāṃsā defends a persisting self as the subject of cognition, duty, memory and Vedic action.**

72

Reply — Buddhist pramāṇa school

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

▯ Apoha explains generality as exclusion grounded in causal convergence: many distinct particulars produce the same practical judgment and action, so a concept is formed without a real universal.

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

▯ Apoha explains generality as exclusion grounded in causal convergence: many distinct particulars produce the same practical judgment and action, so a concept is formed without a real universal.

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

▯▯ Residual force remains: critics argue that the exclusion must already know what to exclude, making apoha circular.

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

Answer-use: ▯ Dignāga and Dharmakīrti reduce the self to a constructed unity imposed on a stream of momentary cognitions.

ANSWER LINE: **▯ Dignāga and Dharmakīrti reduce the self to a constructed unity imposed on a stream of momentary cognitions.**

73

Objection — Śaṃkara-type Advaita

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

▯ If everything is momentary, bondage and liberation cannot belong to one continuing subject.

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

▯ If there is no self, the unity of the knower is unintelligible.

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

▯ If śūnyatā is ultimate, the very denial seems to presuppose a self-luminous witnessing consciousness that makes denial possible.

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

▯ If everything is momentary, bondage and liberation cannot belong to one continuing subject.

ANSWER LINE: **▯ If everything is momentary, bondage and liberation cannot belong to one continuing subject.**

74

Reply — Buddhist two-truths response

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

▯ Buddhism denies that liberation requires an eternal witness; liberation is the cessation of ignorance, craving and appropriation in a causal stream.

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

▯ Buddhism denies that liberation requires an eternal witness; liberation is the cessation of ignorance, craving and appropriation in a causal stream.

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

▯ At paramārtha-satya (ultimate truth), neither person nor witness has intrinsic nature.

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

Answer-use: ▯ Buddhism denies that liberation requires an eternal witness; liberation is the cessation of ignorance, craving and appropriation in a causal stream.

ANSWER LINE: **▯ Buddhism denies that liberation requires an eternal witness; liberation is the cessation of ignorance, craving and appropriation in a causal stream.**

75

Objection — Nyāya and common realist charge

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

▯ If all dharmas are empty, nothing seems to remain for knowledge, ethics or liberation.

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

▯ If the Mādhyamika denies all theses, the denial appears self-refuting.

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

▯ If the Mādhyamika denies all theses, the denial appears self-refuting.

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

Answer-use: ▯ If all dharmas are empty, nothing seems to remain for knowledge, ethics or liberation.

ANSWER LINE: **▯ If all dharmas are empty, nothing seems to remain for knowledge, ethics or liberation.**

76

Reply — Madhyamaka

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

▯ Emptiness means emptiness of own-being, not absence of dependent functioning.

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

▯ The two truths preserve conventional causation, karma and path-practice while denying intrinsic nature.

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

▯ Nāgārjuna's "empty words" strategy treats philosophical utterance as a therapeutic instrument rather than a final ontology.

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

▯ Emptiness means emptiness of own-being, not absence of dependent functioning.

ANSWER LINE: **▯ Emptiness means emptiness of own-being, not absence of dependent functioning.**

77

Objection — Nyāya, Mīmāṃsā and Vedānta

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

▯ If doer and enjoyer are not strictly identical, moral desert appears to disappear.

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

▯ If they are strictly different, punishment or reward would fall on another.

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

▯ If they are strictly different, punishment or reward would fall on another.

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

▯ If doer and enjoyer are not strictly identical, moral desert appears to disappear.

ANSWER LINE: **▯ If doer and enjoyer are not strictly identical, moral desert appears to disappear.**

78

Reply — Buddhist middle position

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

▯ The stream that receives the fruit is causally continuous with the stream-stage that acted.

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

▯ The stream that receives the fruit is causally continuous with the stream-stage that acted.

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

▯ This avoids eternalism while preserving moral responsibility at the conventional level.

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

▯ This avoids eternalism while preserving moral responsibility at the conventional level.

ANSWER LINE: **▯ Buddhism rejects both strict identity and strict difference.**

79

COMMON UPSC TRAPS

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

It is primarily a doctrine of dependent suffering and cessation.

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

▯▯ Trap 6: saying Triratna is inconsistent with no-self because "nobody remains to practise." Buddhism admits a conventional person.

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

▯▯ Trap 2: saying momentariness means non-existence.

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

▯▯ Trap 1: treating pratītyasamutpāda as a simple linear cosmology.

ANSWER LINE: **▯▯ Trap 1: treating pratītyasamutpāda as a simple linear cosmology.**

80

KEYWORD & STATEMENT BANK

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

▯ Kṣaṇikavāda: whatever is real is momentary.

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

▯ Svasaṃvedana: self-awareness of cognition, attacked by Nyāya and central to Buddhist epistemology.

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

▯ Pramāṇaphala: resultant cognition, treated by Dignāga as non-different from the pramāṇa-event.

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

Answer-use: ▯ Pratītyasamutpāda: dependent origination; this being, that becomes.

ANSWER LINE: **▯ Pratītyasamutpāda: dependent origination; this being, that becomes.**

81

Quick examinable statements

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

▯▯ "Ignorance of dependent origination is bondage because it converts process into substance and thereby fuels craving."

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

▯▯ "Ignorance of dependent origination is bondage because it converts process into substance and thereby fuels craving."

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

▯▯ "The person is neither an illusion in the trivial sense nor an ultimate self; it is a valid conventional designation."

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

▯▯ "Buddhist momentariness is not chaos but ordered succession."

ANSWER LINE: **▯▯ "Ignorance of dependent origination is bondage because it converts process into substance and thereby fuels craving."**

82

Pañcaskandhas, no-self and liberation

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

▯ The person is conventionally designated upon form, feeling, perception, formations and consciousness; none is permanent, autonomous or fit to be owned as "this is mine, this I am".

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

▯ Argument: exhaustive analysis finds only conditioned aggregates; their causal dependence explains continuity without a separate ātman.

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

Liberation is cessation of ignorance, craving and appropriation, not the release of a soul-substance.

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

Liberation is cessation of ignorance, craving and appropriation, not the release of a soul-substance.

ANSWER LINE: **▯ The person is conventionally designated upon form, feeling, perception, formations and consciousness; none is permanent, autonomous or fit to be owned as "this is mine, this I am".**

83

Dependent origination, momentariness and emptiness

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

Nāgārjuna's reply is that emptiness itself is dependent designation and preserves conventional causation rather than abolishing it.

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

Madhyamaka draws the anti-essentialist conclusion that dependently originated things are empty of svabhāva.

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

▯ Objection → reply: emptiness seems self-defeating or nihilistic.

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

▯ Kṣaṇikavāda radicalises conditioned arising: what depends on causes cannot possess unchanging efficacy.

ANSWER LINE: **▯ Kṣaṇikavāda radicalises conditioned arising: what depends on causes cannot possess unchanging efficacy.**

84

CORPUS-DRIVEN DEPTH DELTA (complete 2018–2025 audit)

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

▯▯ Priority: Primary ownership rises to 13 of 112 parts and occurs in every year.

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

▯ Trap / answer consequence: Do not identify śūnyatā with non-existence or infer that causal continuity requires a soul; distinguish conventional designation from intrinsic nature.

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

▯ Trap / answer consequence: Do not identify śūnyatā with non-existence or infer that causal continuity requires a soul; distinguish conventional designation from intrinsic nature.

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

▯ Trap / answer consequence: Do not identify śūnyatā with non-existence or infer that causal continuity requires a soul; distinguish conventional designation from intrinsic nature.

ANSWER LINE: **▯▯ Priority: Primary ownership rises to 13 of 112 parts and occurs in every year.**

85

BUDDHIST EPISTEMOLOGY — THE PRAMĀṆA SCHOOL (Dignāga, Dharmakīrti)

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

▯▯ Why this matters for UPSC: Buddhist epistemology is not an isolated logic chapter.

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

It translates nairātmyavāda and kṣaṇikavāda into a theory of knowledge, language and debate.

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

It translates nairātmyavāda and kṣaṇikavāda into a theory of knowledge, language and debate.

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

▯▯ Why this matters for UPSC: Buddhist epistemology is not an isolated logic chapter.

ANSWER LINE: **▯▯ Why this matters for UPSC: Buddhist epistemology is not an isolated logic chapter.**

86

Statement

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

▯ Dignāga and Dharmakīrti accept only two independent pramāṇas (means of valid knowledge): pratyakṣa (perception) and anumāna (inference).

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

▯ Other candidates — upamāna (comparison), arthāpatti (postulation), anupalabdhi (non-apprehension) and śabda (testimony) — are reduced to inference or to perception-plus-inference.

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

▯ Other candidates — upamāna (comparison), arthāpatti (postulation), anupalabdhi (non-apprehension) and śabda (testimony) — are reduced to inference or to perception-plus-inference.

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

Answer-use: ▯ Dignāga and Dharmakīrti accept only two independent pramāṇas (means of valid knowledge): pratyakṣa (perception) and anumāna (inference).

ANSWER LINE: **▯ Dignāga and Dharmakīrti accept only two independent pramāṇas (means of valid knowledge): pratyakṣa (perception) and anumāna (inference).**

87

Argument

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

2. ▯ There are exactly two object-types: svalakṣaṇa (unique particular / self-characterised particular) and sāmānyalakṣaṇa (general character / constructed universal-aspect).

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

1. ▯ A pramāṇa must be individuated by the kind of object it reveals.

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

5. ▯ Therefore there are exactly two pramāṇas.

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

Answer-use: 1. ▯ A pramāṇa must be individuated by the kind of object it reveals.

ANSWER LINE: **1. ▯ A pramāṇa must be individuated by the kind of object it reveals.**

88

Presupposition

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

▯▯ The number of knowledge-sources is fixed by the object-side, not by a mere list of human cognitive habits.

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

▯▯ The number of knowledge-sources is fixed by the object-side, not by a mere list of human cognitive habits.

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

▯▯ There is no third kind of object beyond the unique causal particular and the constructed general character.

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

▯▯ The number of knowledge-sources is fixed by the object-side, not by a mere list of human cognitive habits.

ANSWER LINE: **▯▯ The number of knowledge-sources is fixed by the object-side, not by a mere list of human cognitive habits.**

89

Distinction

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

▯ The svalakṣaṇa is unique, momentary, causally efficient, ineffable and non-conceptual.

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

▯ The sāmānyalakṣaṇa is shareable, expressible and stable only as a conceptual construction.

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

▯▯ This is why Buddhist realism about momentary particulars can coexist with nominalism about universals.

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

Answer-use: ▯ The svalakṣaṇa is unique, momentary, causally efficient, ineffable and non-conceptual.

ANSWER LINE: **▯ The svalakṣaṇa is unique, momentary, causally efficient, ineffable and non-conceptual.**

90

Statement

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

▯ Dharmakīrti adds abhrānta (non-erroneous), so perception is non-conceptual and non-mistaken.

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

▯ Dharmakīrti adds abhrānta (non-erroneous), so perception is non-conceptual and non-mistaken.

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

▯ Dharmakīrti adds abhrānta (non-erroneous), so perception is non-conceptual and non-mistaken.

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

Answer-use: ▯ Dignāga defines perception as kalpanāpoḍha (free from conceptual construction).

ANSWER LINE: **▯ Dignāga defines perception as kalpanāpoḍha (free from conceptual construction).**

91

Why the addition matters

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

▯ Mere vivid presentation is not enough for valid perception.

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

▯ Illusions such as a double moon or the circle produced by a whirling firebrand can be vivid while still mistaken.

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

▯▯ Dharmakīrti's addition protects Buddhist epistemology from counting every non-conceptual appearance as valid knowledge.

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

▯ Mere vivid presentation is not enough for valid perception.

ANSWER LINE: **▯ Mere vivid presentation is not enough for valid perception.**

92

Fourfold division of perception

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

▯▯ Svasaṃvedana connects Buddhist epistemology with Yogācāra idealism because cognition is treated as self-revealing; this is why Nyāya attacks it as collapsing object, cognition and knower.

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

▯▯ Svasaṃvedana connects Buddhist epistemology with Yogācāra idealism because cognition is treated as self-revealing; this is why Nyāya attacks it as collapsing object, cognition and knower.

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

▯▯ Svasaṃvedana connects Buddhist epistemology with Yogācāra idealism because cognition is treated as self-revealing; this is why Nyāya attacks it as collapsing object, cognition and knower.

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

Answer-use: ▯▯ Svasaṃvedana connects Buddhist epistemology with Yogācāra idealism because cognition is treated as self-revealing; this is why Nyāya attacks it as collapsing object, cognition and knower.

ANSWER LINE: **▯▯ Svasaṃvedana connects Buddhist epistemology with Yogācāra idealism because cognition is treated as self-revealing; this is why Nyāya attacks it as collapsing object, cognition and knower.**

93

Statement

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

▯ A word functions through anya-apoha (exclusion of the other): "cow" means "not-non-cow".

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

▯ A word functions through anya-apoha (exclusion of the other): "cow" means "not-non-cow".

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

▯ A word functions through anya-apoha (exclusion of the other): "cow" means "not-non-cow".

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

▯ Apoha (exclusion) says a general term does not denote a real universal (jāti) inhering in particulars.

ANSWER LINE: **▯ Apoha (exclusion) says a general term does not denote a real universal (jāti) inhering in particulars.**

94

Argument

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

1. ▯ Only unique particulars are ultimately real.

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

4. ▯ Therefore generality must be constructed negatively through exclusion.

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

4. ▯ Therefore generality must be constructed negatively through exclusion.

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

3. ▯ If generality were real, one would need real universals; but universals are not perceived and produce the Nyāya problems of inherence and location.

ANSWER LINE: **1. ▯ Only unique particulars are ultimately real.**

95

Presupposition

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

▯▯ Apoha presupposes that a negative / differential function can do the work usually assigned to a positive shared property.

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

▯▯ Apoha presupposes that a negative / differential function can do the work usually assigned to a positive shared property.

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

▯▯ Apoha presupposes that a negative / differential function can do the work usually assigned to a positive shared property.

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

Answer-use: ▯▯ Apoha presupposes that a negative / differential function can do the work usually assigned to a positive shared property.

ANSWER LINE: **▯▯ Apoha presupposes that a negative / differential function can do the work usually assigned to a positive shared property.**

96

Objection — Kumārila Bhaṭṭa and Uddyotakara

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

▯ The exclusion seems circular: to exclude non-cows one must already know what a cow is.

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

▯ A merely negative content seems unable to explain the positive determinate cognition “cow”.

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

▯ It also seems unable to explain the felt similarity among cows.

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

Answer-use: ▯ The exclusion seems circular: to exclude non-cows one must already know what a cow is.

ANSWER LINE: **▯ The exclusion seems circular: to exclude non-cows one must already know what a cow is.**

97

Reply — Dharmakīrti's line

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

▯ Similarity is grounded not in a shared universal but in a shared causal capacity.

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

▯ Many distinct particulars produce the same effect: the same conceptual judgment and the same successful practical activity.

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

▯ Many distinct particulars produce the same effect: the same conceptual judgment and the same successful practical activity.

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

▯ Similarity is grounded not in a shared universal but in a shared causal capacity.

ANSWER LINE: **▯ Similarity is grounded not in a shared universal but in a shared causal capacity.**

98

Statement

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

▯ Sat = arthakriyā-samartha: to be real is to be capable of producing an effect.

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

▯ This criterion ranks the svalakṣaṇa as ultimately real and the sāmānyalakṣaṇa as conventional.

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

▯ Sat = arthakriyā-samartha: to be real is to be capable of producing an effect.

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

Answer-use: ▯ Sat = arthakriyā-samartha: to be real is to be capable of producing an effect.

ANSWER LINE: **▯ Sat = arthakriyā-samartha: to be real is to be capable of producing an effect.**

99

Argument connecting epistemology to kṣaṇikavāda

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

1. ▯ To be real is to be causally efficacious.

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

4. ▯ Therefore whatever is real is momentary — yat sat tat kṣaṇikam.

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

4. ▯ Therefore whatever is real is momentary — yat sat tat kṣaṇikam.

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

Answer-use: 1. ▯ To be real is to be causally efficacious.

ANSWER LINE: **1. ▯ To be real is to be causally efficacious.**

100

Exam payoff

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

▯▯ This is the clean bridge from pramāṇa theory to ontology: what perception ultimately presents is the momentary causally efficient particular; what inference and language manage is the conventional general construction.

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

▯▯ This is the clean bridge from pramāṇa theory to ontology: what perception ultimately presents is the momentary causally efficient particular; what inference and language manage is the conventional general construction.

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

▯▯ This is the clean bridge from pramāṇa theory to ontology: what perception ultimately presents is the momentary causally efficient particular; what inference and language manage is the conventional general construction.

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

Answer-use: ▯▯ This is the clean bridge from pramāṇa theory to ontology: what perception ultimately presents is the momentary causally efficient particular; what inference and language manage is the conventional general construction.

ANSWER LINE: **▯▯ This is the clean bridge from pramāṇa theory to ontology: what perception ultimately presents is the momentary causally efficient particular; what inference and language manage is the conventional general construction.**

101

Statement

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

▯ Dignāga's distinctive thesis is that pramāṇa (instrument of knowledge) and pramāṇaphala (result of knowledge) are not two ultimately different things.

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

▯ The resultant cognition — the determination of the object and the self-awareness of cognition — is non-different from the cognitive event that functions as pramāṇa.

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

▯ Dignāga's distinctive thesis is that pramāṇa (instrument of knowledge) and pramāṇaphala (result of knowledge) are not two ultimately different things.

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

▯ Dignāga's distinctive thesis is that pramāṇa (instrument of knowledge) and pramāṇaphala (result of knowledge) are not two ultimately different things.

ANSWER LINE: **▯ Dignāga's distinctive thesis is that pramāṇa (instrument of knowledge) and pramāṇaphala (result of knowledge) are not two ultimately different things.**

102

Argument

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

▯ On a momentary and non-substantialist ontology, there is no enduring agent-instrument-result triad.

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

▯▯ This shows that Buddhist epistemology is internally driven by anātman and kṣaṇikavāda, not by free-standing formal logic.

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

▯ On a momentary and non-substantialist ontology, there is no enduring agent-instrument-result triad.

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

▯▯ This shows that Buddhist epistemology is internally driven by anātman and kṣaṇikavāda, not by free-standing formal logic.

ANSWER LINE: **▯ On a momentary and non-substantialist ontology, there is no enduring agent-instrument-result triad.**

103

1 The undeclared questions

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

▯ They include whether the world is eternal or not eternal, finite or infinite; whether the jīva (life-principle / self) is the same as or different from the body; and whether the Tathāgata exists after death, does not exist, both, or neither.

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

▯ They include whether the world is eternal or not eternal, finite or infinite; whether the jīva (life-principle / self) is the same as or different from the body; and whether the Tathāgata exists after death, does not exist, both, or neither.

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

▯ They include whether the world is eternal or not eternal, finite or infinite; whether the jīva (life-principle / self) is the same as or different from the body; and whether the Tathāgata exists after death, does not exist, both, or neither.

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

▯ They include whether the world is eternal or not eternal, finite or infinite; whether the jīva (life-principle / self) is the same as or different from the body; and whether the Tathāgata exists after death, does not exist, both, or neither.

ANSWER LINE: **▯ Avyākata / avyākṛta (undeclared / unanswered) questions are questions the Buddha declines to answer in the expected metaphysical format.**

104

Statement

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

▯ The refusal is not a lack of doctrine; it is a disciplined refusal to answer malformed or soteriologically useless questions.

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

▯ The refusal is not a lack of doctrine; it is a disciplined refusal to answer malformed or soteriologically useless questions.

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

▯ The refusal is not a lack of doctrine; it is a disciplined refusal to answer malformed or soteriologically useless questions.

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

▯ The refusal is not a lack of doctrine; it is a disciplined refusal to answer malformed or soteriologically useless questions.

ANSWER LINE: **▯ The refusal is not a lack of doctrine; it is a disciplined refusal to answer malformed or soteriologically useless questions.**

105

Argument

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

5. ▯ Conditioned cognition cannot settle what is framed beyond the conditions of meaningful experience and liberation-oriented practice.

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

2. ▯ The arrow parable in the Cūḷamālukya teaching compares the metaphysical questioner to a man shot with a poisoned arrow who refuses treatment until he learns the archer's caste, name, bow-type and arrow-fletching; he dies before treatment.

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

3. ▯ The questions rest on a false presupposition: they assume a substantial self or substantial world about which the alternatives can be predicated.

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

1. ▯ The questions are na arthasaṃhita (not conducive to the goal / not connected with welfare and liberation).

ANSWER LINE: **1. ▯ The questions are na arthasaṃhita (not conducive to the goal / not connected with welfare and liberation).**

106

3 Fire-going-out simile

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

□□ The point is not that a hidden self travels elsewhere; the categories of directional predication no longer apply once the sustaining conditions have ceased.

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

□□ The point is not that a hidden self travels elsewhere; the categories of directional predication no longer apply once the sustaining conditions have ceased.

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

□□ The point is not that a hidden self travels elsewhere; the categories of directional predication no longer apply once the sustaining conditions have ceased.

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

□ For the Tathāgata-after-death question, early Buddhist teaching uses the fire-going-out simile: when a fire has gone out, it cannot be said to have gone east, west, north or south.

ANSWER LINE: □ **For the Tathāgata-after-death question, early Buddhist teaching uses the fire-going-out simile: when a fire has gone out, it cannot be said to have gone east, west, north or south.**

107

4 Three readings of the silence

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

□ The tradition does not settle the issue in a single uncontested interpretation.

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

□□ For UPSC, combine the second and third readings: the questions are both therapeutically useless and presuppositionally defective.

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

□□ For UPSC, combine the second and third readings: the questions are both therapeutically useless and presuppositionally defective.

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

□ The tradition does not settle the issue in a single uncontested interpretation.

ANSWER LINE: □ **The tradition does not settle the issue in a single uncontested interpretation.**

108

Objection — realist / metaphysical critic

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

□ Silence looks like evasion and leaves Buddhism metaphysically indeterminate.

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

□ Silence looks like evasion and leaves Buddhism metaphysically indeterminate.

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

□ Silence looks like evasion and leaves Buddhism metaphysically indeterminate.

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

Answer-use: □ Silence looks like evasion and leaves Buddhism metaphysically indeterminate.

ANSWER LINE: □ **Silence looks like evasion and leaves Buddhism metaphysically indeterminate.**

109

Reply — Buddhist middle way

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

□ The Buddha's positive teaching is precisely what he declared: Four Noble Truths, dependent origination, path and cessation.

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

□□ Therefore silence is not emptiness of teaching; it is refusal to let the wrong question control the answer.

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

□□ Therefore silence is not emptiness of teaching; it is refusal to let the wrong question control the answer.

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

□ The middle way avoids both śāśvatavāda (eternalism) and ucchedavāda (annihilationism).

ANSWER LINE: □ **The Buddha's positive teaching is precisely what he declared: Four Noble Truths, dependent origination, path and cessation.**

110

1 Buddhism vs Jainism — high-yield distinction

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

□ Buddhism denies substance: what looks like persistence is a conditioned series without an underlying dravya.

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

□ The Jaina jīva is real and omniscient by nature when freed from karmic obstruction; the Buddhist self is a construct designated on skandhas.

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

□ Buddhism denies substance: what looks like persistence is a conditioned series without an underlying dravya.

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

□□ Trap to avoid: do not say both deny the soul.

ANSWER LINE: □ **Both are non-Vedic śramaṇa traditions and both reject a creator God as necessary for liberation.**

111

2 Buddhism vs Advaita — avoid the “crypto-Advaita” trap

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

▯ Both deny that ordinary world-experience is ultimately real in the naive realist sense.

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

▯ Advaita's ultimate is positive, self-luminous Brahman / ātman.

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

▯ Madhyamaka śūnyatā is absence of svabhāva, not a hidden substrate.

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

▯ Madhyamaka śūnyatā is absence of svabhāva, not a hidden substrate.

ANSWER LINE: **▯ Both deny that ordinary world-experience is ultimately real in the naive realist sense.**